

Literature review and gap analysis

Scoping review · 179 studies mapped · 5 gaps stated · 6 databases · PRISMA-ScR · written as the background to a programme grant

This is a redacted sample. It shows the structure and level of detail of a real deliverable. Client names, topics and identifying particulars have been removed or changed. Ask us and we will send one built around a review like yours.

1 Scope, as agreed before searching

The review type was chosen from what the document had to survive. This one is the background section of a five-year programme grant, so the panel is assessing whether the gap is real and fundable rather than whether the synthesis is exhaustive — which makes a scoping review with a strong gap analysis the right instrument, and a full systematic review an expensive way to answer a different question.

Element	As agreed
Review type	Scoping review, reported under PRISMA-ScR
Purpose	Background and justification for a programme grant application
Framework	PECO, with the population axis pre-specified so the map could be built
Databases	PubMed, Embase, Cochrane Library, Scopus, Web of Science, CINAHL
Grey literature	Trial registries, two HTA bodies and two national guideline producers
Limits	2015 onwards, justified by a change in the standard of care; no language restriction
Appraisal	Design recorded for all 179; formal appraisal on the 38 carrying a claim
Output	Narrative synthesis, review matrix, evidence gap map, five gap statements

2 Search and selection

The strategy is supplied line by line for each database with the count it returned and the date it was run, so the review can be updated rather than repeated when the grant is resubmitted.

Stage	n
Records identified from databases	3,912
Records from registries, HTA reports and guidelines	147
Records from citation searching in both directions	88
Duplicates removed	1,402
Records screened on title and abstract	2,745
Records excluded at screening	2,438

Stage	n
Full texts assessed	307
Full texts excluded, with reasons recorded	128
Studies included in the map	179

Four reports were found to describe the same cohort. They are counted once in the map and listed as four references, because counting them separately overstates the evidence by exactly that much.

3 The review matrix

One row per study rather than one paragraph. This is the file clients keep using after the document is finished, because a matrix can be re-sorted, re-grouped and extended, and two hundred studies summarised in prose cannot.

Column	What it holds
Design	Randomised, prospective, retrospective, qualitative, modelled
Setting and country	Including income classification, which the map's rows depend on
Population	Age band, comorbidity and recruitment route, coded from the methods
Exposure and comparator	As described, with the intervention's actual content, not its label
Outcomes measured	Coded to a shared vocabulary, with the original instrument kept alongside
Effect estimate	Where reported, with its interval and the source page
Appraisal	Instrument used and judgement reached, per study
Funding and limitations	As stated by the authors, and what they did not state

Flagged during extraction. Nine studies describe a population in the abstract that the methods section does not support — most often “older adults” for a sample with a mean age of 61. Every study is coded on its methods, not its abstract, and the discrepancies are listed. This only surfaces when someone reads the full text, and it is why a map built from abstracts is not worth building.

4 The evidence gap map

Five populations against five outcome domains, twenty-five cells. The map is supplied as a figure and as the underlying data, so it can be redrawn when the review is updated.

Finding	Cells	What it means for the proposal
No evidence at all	5	The strongest claim available, and the one a panel can verify
Weak designs only	7	Literature exists; evidence does not. A different argument, equally fundable
Studies disagree	2	Nobody has to be persuaded the question matters

Finding	Cells	What it means for the proposal
Thin across a whole row	1	A population systematically excluded, which is a finding in itself

5 The five gap statements

Written as proposal text rather than as findings. Each names a population, an outcome and the study design that would close it, because that is what a committee can assess.

- **Equity of access in older adults.** No study measures whether these interventions widen or narrow access among people over 65. Closed by a cohort with digital literacy and device access measured at baseline, and outcomes reported by that stratum rather than adjusted for it.
- **Cost-effectiveness in low-resource settings.** Four effectiveness trials, no economic evaluation — in the setting where cost decides adoption. Closed by a trial-based economic evaluation alongside an existing trial, using local unit costs rather than transferred ones.
- **Cost-effectiveness generally — a methodological gap.** Six studies exist; five are modelled analyses resting on assumptions the trials never tested. Closed by a within-trial evaluation rather than another model.
- **Quality of life in older adults — a contradiction.** Two trials report opposite directions of effect, and neither cites the other. Closed by a trial powered for quality of life as a primary outcome, using one validated instrument.
- **Multimorbidity — a population gap.** Thin across every outcome, because most studies exclude people on multiple medicines. Closed by a pragmatic trial that makes polypharmacy an inclusion criterion rather than an exclusion.

6 What is handed over

- The review itself, structured by theme and formatted to the funder's template.
- The search strategy for every database, line by line, with counts and dates.
- The PRISMA-ScR flow diagram as an editable figure.
- The full review matrix, 179 rows, as a spreadsheet you keep and can extend.
- Evidence tables grouped by theme, formatted for direct insertion.
- The evidence gap map as a figure and as the underlying data.
- A deduplicated reference library in EndNote, Mendeley or Zotero, styled to your format.

Pubrica supports the work; authorship remains yours. Where our contribution should be acknowledged under ICMJE, the handover drafts the wording for you to approve, and any AI-assisted searching or drafting is declared in the methods.

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